seemingly agreeing with him, thinks 'the excesses committed by the Hindu forces against the Muslim population and sacred places in their invasions of Ahmadnagar and Golconda had no small share in rousing feelings against Rama Raya'.[35] Apparently even his Muslim allies in Bijapur were turned off by it.

This and sundry political factors soon led the sultans to realize that on their own, they stood no chance against Rama Raya, who now had enormous wealth and resources. In 1564, a peace treaty was struck between the two rival factions of sultans and sealed with a marriage deal. A military alliance was forged between four of the five sultanates (excluding Berar) to jointly tackle Rama Raya. Preparations for a great war began in earnest on both sides. With more troops at his disposal, Rama Raya felt confident of victory, though in recent years the sultanates had opened up a 'wide gap in military technology' by integrating field artillery in their ranks.[36]

A pitched battle took place using both artillery and hand-to-hand combat. Nearly 3500 Portuguese mercenaries fought on the side of Vijayanagar.[37] Vijayanagar's 'gunners were Portuguese or Muslim, just as the light horse- and foot-soldiers of the Muslim regimes were often [Hindu] Marathas'.[38] At first Rama Raya, now eighty years old, seemed to be winning. Then came a sudden reversal, according to Firishta. After a blistering artillery attack 'charged with copper coins' for shrapnel, a unit of the enemy's cavalry cut through an opening in the centre and reached Rama Raya. They captured and decapitated him, and hoisted his head on a spear. This caused panic among his troops and they began fleeing the battlefield. A rival account from a later Italian traveller, however, claims that the decisive factor in Rama Raya's defeat was the betrayal by two of his Muslim generals. This threw their side in chaos, enabling a unit of the enemy's cavalry to reach Rama Raya, decapitate him and hoist his head on a spear.[39] It is now impossible to say which of these two accounts is true. If historians pick one over the other, they do so for their own reasons. Either way, Vijayanagar's troops were routed. Many were pursued and slaughtered, says Firishta, and a river nearby ran red with blood. All along, 'Golkonda's Telugu [Hindu] soldiery remained faithful to their Muslim ruler against the Hindu king'.[40]